

Claude Opus 4.6

February 16, 2026

I have a Latin letter written in late-fourteenth century Gothic secretarial hand. I would like you to do your best to transcribe it.

2:35 PM

Grappled with medieval script abbreviations and paleographic uncertainties

Here's my best attempt at this letter. It's clearly from Queen Violant de Bar to Pope Clement VII, dated February 1387, concerning a benefice matter. I'll use parentheses for expanded abbreviations and brackets for uncertain readings.

Transcription:

Beatissime pa(ter) p(er) requestes au(tem)/ias preces o(mn)i co(ntent)as · p(er) nos dict(a)s
iam paru(m) an(te) exactis oratore destinatos · et(iam) n(ost)ro incommutabile a(n)i(m)o
insidere(n)t p(ro) obtetu co(n)firmacionis d(e) collacione fa- mu(n)t cu(m) o(mn)e ordinaria
p(er) ven(erabilem) in x(pist)o p(at)rem Longariu(m) Ep(iscopu)m Urgellen(sem) dilecto
n(ost)ro Jacobo d(e) auellaneda cl(er)ico Barch(inonensi) d(i)ocesis can(oni)a p(re)benda
cu(m) suis iurib(us) tu(n)c vacat(is) i(n) eccl(esi)a Urgellen(si) p(er) morte(m) Bonanati d(e)
Pedro i(n)no q(uo)d dies suos in cu(ria) Romana d(e) fi(ni)uisse · &c · ite(rum) supplicat
cora(m) q(uam) collacio(n)e(m) p(re)d(i)c(t)am n(ost)ri honoris intuitu co(n)fir(m)are
digne(tur) n(ost)ris d(i)c(t)i Jacobi q(ui) bone e(st) indolis z q(uam)u(is) erat iuuenis pura
i(n)ta p(er)q(uam) a(n)i(m)u(m) co(n)ti(n)ue(n)t n(on) ad d(omin)i [...] offic(ium) mutu(m)
d(omi)no modo se(m)p(er) au(tem) arden(ti) affec(tione) demonstra(re) dign(etur) medici[s]
q(ue) firmare no(n) obstante u(t)no reuocatt(a) collacio(n)e i(n)[...] v(est)r(a) d(e) fo(r)t(asse)
p(er) Sede(m) ap(osto)licam p(ro)ui- solu(m)[?] cu(m) fieri ab eade(m) sede suo t(em)p(or)e
i(n)d(e) congruent(er) e(men)da humil(iter) supplicat(i)o(n)is hoc en(im) p(re) p(re)t(er)
recipie(n)s p(ro) dono ac mu(ner)e sp(eci)ali v(est)r(a)e gra(tia)s 6 · e(tc) · humillimas
r(e)feren(s) et laudes · Alma p(ro)na(m) v(estram) creator om(n)iu(m) sacros(an)cte ac
universali eccl(es)ie felicit(er) p(re)- esse faciat p(er) t(em)p(or)a longiora · Dat(a)

Barch(inone) sub n(ost)ro co(n)sueto sigillo ferreo p(ri)vy de de ffebroary Ano a Nat(ivitate)
D(omi)ni M°CCC°LXXX°VII° · la Reyn(a)

[Address/subscriptio:]

Beatissimo ac b(ea)tissimo in x(pist)o p(at)ri z d(omi)no d(omi)no Clementi d(ei) gr(ati)a
d(ignis)s(i)mo sacros(an)cte Romane ac vniuersat eccl(esi)e sum(m)o pont(ifici)

[Right margin, chancery note:] D(omi)na Regina ma(n)d(avit) Petro d(e) Besanta

[New letter begins:]

Regina Arago(n)

Cupientes aude vt dit(t)o n(ost)ro Jacobo d'auellaneda fili(us) fi(de)lio n(ost)ri Bartholomei
d'auellano(s)

Notes on difficulties and content:

Several passages in the body gave me real trouble — the abbreviation density is very high, and certain letter forms (especially the scribe's *r*, *c*, and *t*) are nearly indistinguishable in places. Lines 6–9 in particular I'm least confident about.

The gist of the letter: Violant is writing to Clement VII, reiterating a previous supplication (sent via an orator) requesting papal confirmation of a collation made by Longarius, Bishop of Urgell, granting a canonry and prebend in the church of Urgell to her protégé **Jacobo de Avellaneda**, a cleric of the Barcelona diocese. The benefice was vacant through the death of one **Bonanatus de Pedro**, who died at the Roman Curia. She praises Jacobo's good character and youth, and humbly asks for confirmation notwithstanding any possible revocation or competing apostolic provision.

The date is February 1387 (Nativity style), from Barcelona, sealed with her customary iron seal (*sigillo ferreo*). The chancery note confirms it was issued by command of the Queen, through the scribe Pedro de Besanta. A second letter on the same subject (concerning the same Jacobo de Avellaneda, son of Bartholomew de Avellaneda) begins at the bottom.

Would you like me to attempt a fuller working translation, or focus on any particular section?

I am going to paste a transcription of the same image done by another LLM. Please look it over and use it to consider parts of the transcription that were ambiguous or difficult for

you. Then make adjustments to your transcription and provide it again in full. Here is the transcription: Beatissime pater, post humiles [et] deuotas recommendationes ad pedes vestros s[anct]it[as]. Per nos dicte iam pridem v[est]re s[ancti]tati deuote destinatos extitit vno incommutabili vno insistere propterea confirmationis [et] collationis sen[tentia] nup[er] auct[orita]te ordinaria per ven[erabilem] in x̃po (christo) patrem Linguinu[m] Ẽpm (episcopum) Urgellen[sem] factas n[ost]ro Iacobo d'auellaneda clerico barch[ino]n[ensis] d' cañ[on]i[ca] [et] prebenda cu[m] suis iurib[us] tunc vacantib[us] i[n] eccl[esi]a Urgellen[si] p[er] mortem Bonanati d' podio nunq[uam] dicte suos in curia Romana de finuisse. E[t] p[ro]inde supplicat[i]onem exorrimus quat[enus] collatione[m] p[re]dictam n[ost]ri hono[r]is intuitu exigenib[us] meritis d[ic]ti Iacobi q[ui] bone e[st] indolis [et] q[ui] in[us] erat[is] iuris p[er]itia ita xp[ist]ianum (christianum) docum[en]tum q[ui] ad d[ic]t[u]m vnu[m] officiū n[ost]ru[m] digno modo senit assequendam affec[tu] demonstra[n]t dignu[m] modum confirmare non obstante vno reuocata collatione [et] iud[i]c[i]o vt dicitur for[er] p[er] sedem ap[osto]lica[m] Eciam volum[us] cu[m] fieri ab eade[m] sede suo tep[o]re iud[i]c[i]o congruente emenda sumit[er] supplicat[ur] Hoc enim p[er] p[at]re p[re]cipiem[us] p[ro] dono ac munere s[an]ct[i] v[ost]re gratia [et] c[etera]. Humillimas ressem[us] [et] laudes. Alma p[er]sonam v[est]ram creator o[mn]ium sacros[an]cte ac vniu[er]salis eccl[esi]e felicit[er] p[re] esse faciat p[er] tep[o]ra longiora.

Show more

2:40 PM

Reconciled competing transcriptions against manuscript evidence systematically

Thank you — comparing the two transcriptions against the image is very helpful. The second transcription has some clearly superior readings in places, and I had some better readings elsewhere. Let me go through the key differences and produce a revised version.

Key improvements I'm adopting from the second transcription:

- **"pridem"** for "some time ago" — much better Latin than my "parum ante"
- **"pro obtentu"** (for the obtaining of) — better than my "pro obtetu"
- **"nuper auctoritate ordinaria"** — far better Latin and better match to the letterforms than my garbled "mu(n)t cu(m) o(mn)e ordinaria"
- **"de Podio"** instead of my "de Pedro" — a well-attested medieval Catalan surname (from *Puig*)
- **"vacantib(us)"** — correct full form, better than my truncated "vacatis"
- **"quatenus"** — makes much better syntactic sense than my "q(uam)"

- **"exigentib(us) meritis"** — "on account of the demanding merits" works well contextually
- **"humiliter supplicatur"** — cleaner than my reading

Places where I think my reading was better or the second transcription is questionable:

- The opening of line 1: "post humiles et deuotas recommendationes ad pedes vestros sanctitas" doesn't match what I see — I see something closer to "preces" and "requestes"
- **"Lunguinum"** — I'm not confident in either of our readings; this is the Bishop of Urgell and the name is hard to resolve
- **"nunquam"** — doesn't make sense in context; the phrase describes Bonanatus dying (*dies suos definuisse*) at the Roman Curia
- **"xpistianum christianum documentum"** — very unlikely; I think this passage describes Jacobo's youth and character
- **"factas nostro iacobo"** — I believe there's a word before "nostro" (possibly "dilecto" or "dicto")

Revised Transcription:

Beatissime pa(ter) · p(er) requestes au(tem) preces [et] co(ntentas) · p(er) nos dich(a)s iam pridem v(est)re s(ancti)tati deuote destinatos · ext(it)it vno incommutabili a(n)i(m)o insistere pro obtentu co(n)firmacio(n)is (et) collacio(n)is se(n)te(n)tia) nup(er) auct(orita)te ordinaria p(er) ven(erabilem) in x(pist)o p(at)rem [...]inu(m) Ep(iscopu)m Urgellen(sem) · (di)c(t)o n(ost)ro iacobo d'auellaneda cl(er)ico Barch(inonensi) d(i)ocesis) · can(oni)c(atu) (et) p(re)benda cu(m) suis iurib(us) tunc vacantib(us) i(n) eccl(esi)a Urgellen(si) p(er) mortem Bonanati d(e) Podio · nu(n)q(uam)[?] dich(o)s dies suos in cu(ria) Romana de finuisse · (et) c(etera) · ite(rum) supplicat(ionem) exori(m)us quat(enu)s collacione(m) p(re)d(i)c(t)am n(ost)ri hono(r)is intuitu · exigentib(us) meritis d(i)c(t)i iacobi q(ui) bone e(st) indolis (et) q(uam)u(is) erat iuuenis · pura i(n)ta p(er)q(uam) a(n)i(m)u(m) contin(et) n(on) ad d(i)c(tu)m vnu(m) officiu(m) mut(uum) d(omin)o modo se(m)p(er) au(tem) arden(ti) affec(tione) demonstra(n)t dignu(m) medie[?] q(ue) firmare no(n) obstante v(t)no reuocata collacio(n)e (et) i(u)d(ici)o v(t) dicit(ur) for(san) p(er) Sede(m) ap(osto)licam · Ecia(m) volu(mus) cu(m) fieri ab eade(m) Sede suo te(m)p(or)e i(u)d(ici)o congruente e(men)da humil(iter) supplicat(ur) · Hoc eni(m) p(re) p(re)t(er)[?] recipien(s) p(ro) dono ac mu(ner)e

sp(eci)ali v(est)re gra(tie) · (et) c(etera) · humillimas refere(n)s (et) laudes · Alma
p(er)sona(m) v(est)ram creator o(mn)iu(m) sacros(an)cte ac vniu(er)sali eccl(esi)e felicit(er)
p(re)- esse faciat p(er) te(m)p(or)a longiora · Dat(a) Barch(inone) sub n(ost)ro co(n)suet
sigillo secreto · p(ri)m(o) die de ffebroarii · Ano a Nat(ivitate) D(omi)ni M°CCC°LXXX°VII° · la
Reyn(a)

[Address:]

Beatissimo ac b(ea)tissimo in x(pist)o p(at)ri (et) d(omi)no d(omi)no Clementi d(e)i gr(ati)a
d(ignis)s(i)mo sacros(an)cte Romane ac vniu(er)sal(is) eccl(esi)e sum(m)o pont(ifici)

[Chancery note:] D(omi)na Regina ma(n)d(auit) Petro d(e) Besanta

[New letter incipit:]

Regina Arago(n)

Cupientes aude(m) vt di(le)c(t)o n(ost)ro Iacobo d'auellaneda · fili(us) fideli(s) n(ost)ri
Bartholomei d'auellane(da)

Remaining difficulties:

The passage in lines 7–9 (from "pura inta perquam" through "dignum medie") remains the most resistant to confident reading. The syntax is tortured even by chancery Latin standards, and the abbreviation density combined with the secretary hand makes several words genuinely ambiguous. I suspect the passage is arguing that despite Jacobo's youth, his character and devotion make him worthy of the office — but the precise wording eludes me.

The bishop's name (line 3) also remains uncertain. Neither "Longarius" nor "Lunguinus" is a bishop of Urgell I can readily identify for 1387. Do you have any leads on who held the see at that date? That might help resolve the name paleographically.

You are doing very well with this task. I can tell you that the name in line 3 begins with a capital B and that based on my experienced I am quite sure that the name is Berengarium Comtem Urgellen, meaning Berenguer the Count of Urgell.

2:45 PM

Reconciled paleographic correction with historical context and revised transcription accordingly

That's an excellent correction and makes much more sense — thank you. It also forces me to reconsider the formula preceding the name. If this is a count rather than a bishop, then what I was reading as "ven(erabilem) in x(pist)o p(at)rem" — the standard episcopal address — must be something different. Perhaps "per il·lustre/inclitum" or another formula appropriate for secular nobility. Let me revise the relevant passage and provide the full transcription again.

Revised Transcription:

Beatissime pa(ter) · p(er) requestes au(tem) preces [et] co(ntentas) · p(er) nos dich(a)s iam pridem v(est)re s(ancti)tati deuote destinatos · ext(it)it vno incommutabili a(n)i(m)o insistere pro obtentu co(n)firmacio(n)is (et) collacio(n)is se(n)te(n)tia) nup(er) auct(orita)te ordinaria p(er) ven[?] in x(pist)o p(at)rem[?] Berengarium Comtem Urgellen(sem) · (di)c(t)o n(ost)ro Iacobo d'auellaneda cl(er)ico Barch(inonensi) d(iocesis) · can(oni)c(atu) (et) p(re)benda cu(m) suis iurib(us) tunc vacantib(us) i(n) eccl(esi)a Urgellen(si) p(er) mortem Bonanati d(e) Podio · nu(n)q(uam)[?] dich(o)s dies suos in cu(ria) Romana de finuisse · (et) c(etera) · ite(rum) supplicat(ionem) exori(m)us quat(enu)s collacione(m) p(re)d(i)c(t)am n(ost)ri hono(r)is intuitu · exigentib(us) meritis d(i)c(t)i Iacobi q(ui) bone e(st) indolis (et) q(uam)u(is) erat iuuenis · pura i(n)ta p(er)q(uam) a(n)i(m)u(m) contin(et) n(on) ad d(i)c(tu)m vnu(m) officiu(m) mut(uum) d(omin)o modo se(m)p(er) au(tem) arden(ti) affec(tione) demonstra(n)t dignu(m) medie[?] q(ue) firmare no(n) obstante v(t)no reuocata collacio(n)e (et) i(u)d(ici)o v(t) dicit(ur) for(san) p(er) Sede(m) ap(osto)licam · Ecia(m) volu(mus) cu(m) fieri ab eade(m) Sede suo te(m)p(or)e i(u)d(ici)o congruente e(men)da humil(iter) supplicat(ur) · Hoc eni(m) p(re) p(re)t(er)[?] recipien(s) p(ro) dono ac mu(ner)e sp(eci)ali v(est)re gra(tie) · (et) c(etera) · humillimas refere(n)s (et) laudes · Alma p(er)sona(m) v(est)ram creator o(mn)iu(m) sacros(an)cte ac vniu(er)sali eccl(esi)e felicit(er) p(re)- esse faciat p(er) te(m)p(or)a longiora · Dat(a) Barch(inone) sub n(ost)ro co(n)sueto sigillo secreto · p(rim)o die de ffebroarii · Ano a Nat(ivitate) D(omi)ni M°CCC°LXXX°VII° · la Reyn(a)

[Address:]

Beatissimo ac b(ea)tissimo in x(pist)o p(at)ri (et) d(omi)no d(omi)no Clementi d(e)i gr(ati)a d(ignis)s(i)mo sacros(an)cte Romane ac vniu(er)sal(is) eccl(esi)e sum(m)o pont(ifici)

[Chancery note:] D(omi)na Regina ma(n)d(auit) Petro d(e) Besanta

[New letter incipit:]

Regina Arago(n)

Cupientes aude(m) vt di(le)c(t)o n(ost)ro Iacobo d'auellaneda · fili(us) fidei(s) n(ost)ri
Bartholomei d'auellane(da)

Notes on this revision:

The identification of Berenguer, Count of Urgell, is very interesting. It raises the question of what authority a secular lord is exercising over an ecclesiastical benefice — presumably patronage rights over the cathedral chapter. The formula preceding his name on line 3 needs reconsideration; I've left question marks where I was previously reading the episcopal formula. Could you make out what precedes "Berengarium"? It may be something like "inclitum" or "nobilem" rather than "venerabilem in Christo patrem."

The passage in lines 7–9 continues to trouble me. Do you have any sense of what's happening syntactically there? I wonder if it's describing Jacobo's qualifications — his good character despite his youth — and arguing that he is worthy (*dignum*) of confirmation.

Actually it could be that Berenguer is the Bishop of Urgell.

2:46 PM

Reconsidered ecclesiastical title and validated standard episcopal formula

That's worth reconsidering! If Berenguer is the Bishop of Urgell, then my original reading of the formula actually works perfectly — "ven(erabilem) in x(pist)o p(at)rem Berengarium Ep(iscopu)m Urgellen(sem)" is the absolutely standard way to refer to a bishop in papal correspondence of this period.

The key question is the word after "Berengarium" — whether it reads "Comtem" or something abbreviated as "Ep(iscopu)m." In the context of a collation of a canonry and prebend in the church of Urgell, a bishop exercising *auctoritate ordinaria* (ordinary authority) makes much more institutional sense than a count. Collation of cathedral benefices was precisely the kind of thing bishops did by ordinary authority; a count doing so would require more explanation.

Do you happen to know who held the see of Urgell in early 1387? That would settle it. If there was a Bishop Berenguer at that date, the episcopal reading is almost certainly correct and the line would read:

nup(er) auct(orita)te ordinaria p(er) ven(erabilem) in x(pist)o p(at)rem Berengarium
Ep(iscopu)m Urgellen(sem) · (di)c(t)o n(ost)ro Iacobo

which is formulaically perfect. Shall I search for the episcopal succession of Urgell to try to confirm?

At this point, I would like to pause on the searching for this person and instead I would like you to create an English translation of this Latin letter as best you can.

2:47 PM

Methodically translated medieval Latin letter from Queen to Pope

Here is my best working translation, with notes on the difficult passages:

Most Holy Father, through the requests and prayers contained [in letters] already some time ago devoutly dispatched by us to Your Holiness, it has been [our resolve] with one unchangeable mind to insist upon the obtaining of confirmation of the collation and its sentence, recently [made] by ordinary authority through the venerable father in Christ Berenguer, Bishop of Urgell, to our said Jacobo de Avellaneda, cleric of the Barcelona diocese, of the canonry and prebend with their rights then vacant in the church of Urgell through the death of Bonanatus de Podio, who is said to have ended his days at the Roman Curia, etc.

Again we make supplication that the aforesaid collation, out of regard for our honor [and] on account of the worthy merits of the said Jacobo — who is of good character, and although he is young, [possesses such purity of spirit and devotion?] that he demonstrates himself worthy of the said office by his constant and ardent affection toward the Lord — [Your Holiness might] deign to confirm, notwithstanding any revocation of the collation or judgment said to have been made perhaps by the Apostolic See. Also we wish, when amendment shall be made by the same See in its own time with fitting judgment, that it be humbly requested.

For this indeed, receiving [it] as a gift and special favor of Your Grace, etc., rendering most humble [thanks] and praises. May the nourishing Creator of all cause Your person to preside happily over the holy and universal Church for a long time to come.

Given at Barcelona, under our customary secret seal, the first day of February, in the year from the Nativity of the Lord 1387. **The Queen.**

[Addressed to:] To the most blessed and holy father and lord in Christ, Lord Clement, by the grace of God most worthy supreme pontiff of the holy Roman and universal Church.

[Chancery note:] The Lady Queen commanded [this letter]. Pedro de Besanta [wrote it].

Summary of content: Violant de Bar is writing to Clement VII to follow up on a previous supplication. She is requesting papal confirmation of a benefice — specifically a canonry and prebend in the cathedral of Urgell — that was collated by the Bishop of Urgell using his ordinary authority to her protégé Jacobo de Avellaneda, a Barcelonan cleric. The benefice became vacant when its previous holder, Bonanatus de Podio, died at the papal curia. Violant is concerned that the collation may have been revoked or overridden by a competing apostolic provision from the papal See, and she asks Clement to confirm the bishop's original grant regardless.

The passage I've marked with brackets and question marks (lines 7–9 of the transcription) remains my least confident section. The general sense — that Jacobo is young but virtuous and worthy — seems clear, but the precise syntax is difficult to resolve.

Shall I put this into a document for you?

At this time, I would like to shift to researching the people mentioned in this letter. Can you find any mention of Jacobo de Avellaneda, Berenguer Bishop of Urgell, or Bonanatus de Podio in the academic secondary literature? Please provide links to what you find.

2:51 PM

Thinking about locating academic sources for three medieval historical figures

Let me search for each of these individuals.

Identified Bishop Berenguer de Eril and prepared biographical research



ICNL



A





Excellent — the first result confirms our bishop. Berenguer de Eril, O.S.B., was Bishop of Urgell from 20 September 1370 until his death on 3 May 1 [Catholic-Hierarchy](#)387. So Violant's letter of February 1387 was written just three months before his death. Let me now search for the other individuals.

Verified historical figure and pivoted to researching remaining subjects

W



Good. Now let me search for the other two individuals.

Pursued additional searches after initial inquiries yielded no results



W

.PUB

W



W

R⁶

Let me try a few more targeted searches.

Excavated historical records; located bishop documentation, minor clerics eluded discovery



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R⁶



Here's a summary of what I was able to find:

Berenguer de Eril, Bishop of Urgell — This is the best-documented figure. Berenguer de Eril, O.S.B., was appointed Bishop of Urgell on 20 September 1370 and held the see until his death on 3 May 1387. [Catholic-Hierarchy](#) He was a Benedictine monk from the prominent Erill baronial family of the Pallars Jussà and Alta Ribagorça. The Erill family had deep ties to the church — an earlier Berenguer de Erill served as Bishop of Lleida between 1205 and 1236, during the reign of James I. [Wikipedia](#) The family were patrons of the famous Romanesque churches of the Vall de Boí (now a UNESCO World Heritage Site). His Catholic-Hierarchy entry is here: <https://www.catholic-hierarchy.org/bishop/beril.html>

Notably, Violant's letter is dated February 1387 — just three months before Berenguer de Eril's death. This may explain the urgency: if the bishop was already ailing, Violant may have wanted papal confirmation locked in before the see fell vacant and the situation became more complicated.

Jacobo de Avellaneda (and his father Bartholomeus de Avellaneda) — I found no trace of either figure in the secondary literature available online. This is not unusual for a minor cleric seeking a cathedral canonry; such individuals typically appear only in archival registers, not in published scholarship, unless they later rose to greater prominence. The Avellaneda name doesn't appear to be well-attested in the Crown of Aragon context, which makes this letter all the more interesting as a document of Violant's patronage network.

Bonanatus de Podio — Similarly, I found nothing. The Latinized surname *de Podio* corresponds to the Catalan *de Puig* — an extremely common toponym. Without a more specific identifier, this deceased canon of Urgell doesn't surface in any online secondary literature.

Pedro de Besanta (the chancery scribe) — No results in the secondary literature either.

Where to look next: The most promising avenue for all three lesser figures would be the published registers of the Archive of the Crown of Aragon (particularly Violant's own registers, which have been extensively studied by Dawn Bratsch-Prince and Claire Ponsich), Cebrià Baraut's published documents of the cathedral of Urgell in the journal *Urgellia*, and the papal registers of Clement VII's Avignon obedience (which would record the supplication if it was processed). The Bratsch-Prince article on Violant's self-representation and Ponsich's work on her correspondence networks would be the most relevant secondary scholarship for contextualizing the letter:

- Bratsch-Prince, Dawn. "The Politics of Self-Representation in the Letters of Violant de Bar (1365–1431)." *Medieval Encounters* 12, no. 1 (2006): 2–25. [ResearchGate link](#)
- Ponsich, Claire. "Un témoignage de la culture en Cerdagne. La correspondance de Violant de Bar (1380–1431)." *Études Roussillonnaises* XXI (2005): 147–193. [HAL link](#)
- Rosillo-Luque, A. (2025). "Violant de Bar." In Sauer et al., eds., *The Palgrave Encyclopedia of Medieval Women's Writing*. [Springer link](#)

Want to be notified when Claude responds?

[Claude is AI and can make mistakes. Please double-check cited sources.](#)

